1. Evaluate the extent to which economic motives were the leading cause of Japanese imperialism in the period circa 1900–1945.

Document 1

Source: "Why do Japan's businessmen insist on war against Russia?," editorial published in the *Tokyo Keizai zasshi (Tokyo Economist)*, Japan's leading business journal, 1903

"Today, we join the countless private Japanese entrepreneurs and industrialists who are advocating for a war against Russia over the Manchurian problem. In recent days, we have heard reports that Russia has introduced new regulations increasing the tax it levies on non-Russian ships docking at the harbor in Port Arthur,[1] so that Japanese ships would have to pay more than 12 times the amount of port tax that Russian ships do. If Russia occupies other parts of Manchuria [a region of East Asia to the north of Korea and to the northeast of China] and extends this method of levying taxes there, Japanese businesses may have to endure terrible hardships, possibly cutting us out of the Manchurian trade altogether.

In short, as long as Russia retains a foothold in Manchuria, we must recognize on the basis of her past record that she will do all in her power to hold Japan's trade down. It is better to take the initiative and force a solution than to wait until circumstances have further forced our hand."

[1] A major commercial hub and point of entry of foreign goods into Manchuria, Port Arthur had been leased by the Qing Empire to Russia since 1898.

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Document 2

Source: Fumimaro Konoe, diplomat and advisor to the prime minister of Japan, "Reject the Anglo-American-Centered Peace," essay published in the political magazine *Japan and the Japanese*, Tokyo, 1918

"As the history of England and France shows, they long ago occupied the less civilized regions of the world, made them into colonies, and had no problem monopolizing them for their own profit. Therefore, not only Germany but all late-developing countries were in the position of having no land to acquire.

England has lost no time in trumpeting its self-sufficiency, and now it, together with America, is advocating that other countries be denied access to colonies. Such are the contradictions between what England and America say and what they do. If the principle that no country should establish new colonies is carried out at the coming peace conference,[2] it would be a great economic blow to Japan. Germany's need to overthrow this order was quite justified, though the means it chose were unfortunate because they were based on militarism. Nevertheless, as a Japanese I cannot help feeling deep sympathy for what Germany had to do.

Japan is limited in territory, poor in natural resources, and has a meager domestic market for manufactured products. If England closed off its colonies, how would we be able to assure our nation's secure survival? In such a case, the need to ensure its survival would compel Japan to attempt to overthrow the status quo as Germany did before the war."

[2] Konoe was a member of Japan's delegation to the 1919–1920 Paris Peace Conference.

Document 3

Source: *Manifesto Against the Japanese Invasion of Manchuria*, published by The Allied Korean Organizations in New York, a community organization of Korean Americans, 1931

"Japan gained her foothold in the continent when she annexed Korea in 1910 regardless of her repeated solemn vows to recognize the sovereignty and independence of the Korean Kingdom. Japan violated so many treaties and agreements that it is absurd to believe that there is any sincerity in Japan's motive to abide with or to live up to any kind of international treaties or agreements in which she has been or will be one of the participants. After the annexation of Korea under the pretext of Asia for Asians, Japan has been steadily looking for a chance to make Manchuria a second victim of her shameless imperialistic conquest. One major railroad in Manchuria was already built with Japanese capital, and another one is almost halfway completed. It is only a matter of time before the most fertile region of Manchuria would be entirely under the Japanese domination."

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Document 4

Source: Kanji Ishiwara, Japanese army officer stationed in Manchuria, "Personal Opinion on the Manchuria-Mongolia Problem," essay written in 1931, shortly before he masterminded the diplomatic crisis that led to the Japanese occupation of Manchuria

"For a nation-state to play an active role in the world, its most essential requirement is a favorable national defense position. As American economic power advances, the United States will become the champion of the Western peoples. Our country must resist the encroachments of Russia to the north as it simultaneously confronts British and American power to the south. Northern Manchuria is of strategic value to Japan. If our country brings northern Manchuria under its influence, Russia will find it extremely difficult to advance to the east. It will not be difficult to block Russia simply by building up our strength in Manchuria and Mongolia. If our country is relieved of its burden to the north, it can then make bold plans for China and the South Sea region.

The Manchuria-Mongolia region is of enormous strategic importance with respect to the destiny and development of our country. If the Manchuria-Mongolia region is brought under our influence, then our control over Korea will be stabilized. If our country shows firm determination in resolving the Manchuria-Mongolia problem through force, it can assume a position of leadership toward China; it can promote China's unity and stability; and it can guarantee peace in the East."

Document 5

Source: Eliot Janeway, United States journalist, article published in the *New York Times*, 1937

"Japan's new offensive in the Beijing region[3] is her answer to the question upon which the future of Asia apparently hinges: Who is to use the abundant raw materials of China? Both China and Japan greatly desire these materials. If Japan prevails in this, it will mean far more than the shrinking of China's boundaries. The industrialization of China will be fatally hampered by the loss of this principal source of raw materials. Japan requires the products of this area for its own uses, but even if she did not, she would have had to strike here in order to prevent China's industrialization and the unification which she fears would result from it.

The Shaanxi province has the very commodities that Japan needs most desperately. If Japan's steel industry is to become self-sufficient, it will need the 300,000,000 tons of ore which lie in Shaanxi. Likewise, Japan is facing coal shortages. The coal her iron and steel industries use must be imported, and again Shaanxi is the nearest source."

[3] A reference to the fighting during the Second Sino-Japanese War (1937–1945), in which Japan invaded China and fought against a coalition of Nationalist and Communist Chinese forces

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Document 6

Source: Toichi Nawa, Japanese economist and professor at the Osaka University of Commerce, *The Japanese Cotton Spinning Industry and the Question of the Supply of Raw Cotton*, book published in Osaka, 1937

"Would it be possible, as many have suggested, for Japan to put North China under our control so that we have full access to her resources, including her rich cotton fields? The answer, in my view, is "no." China is a backward society, based on a traditional pattern of landholding and lacking modern industries. It would require extraordinarily large expenditures to develop its economy, block interventions from third countries, and develop policies to mitigate Chinese resistance. It is highly doubtful that Japan has the necessary capital and resources to cope with such a monumental task.

The foreign trade statistics of the last few years show that the more we expand the productive capacity of our industries in preparation to extend Japanese rule to mainland Asia, the greater our dependence on the world market and the imports of raw materials becomes. The lure of empire building in Asia is therefore a grave danger for our country's economic advance."

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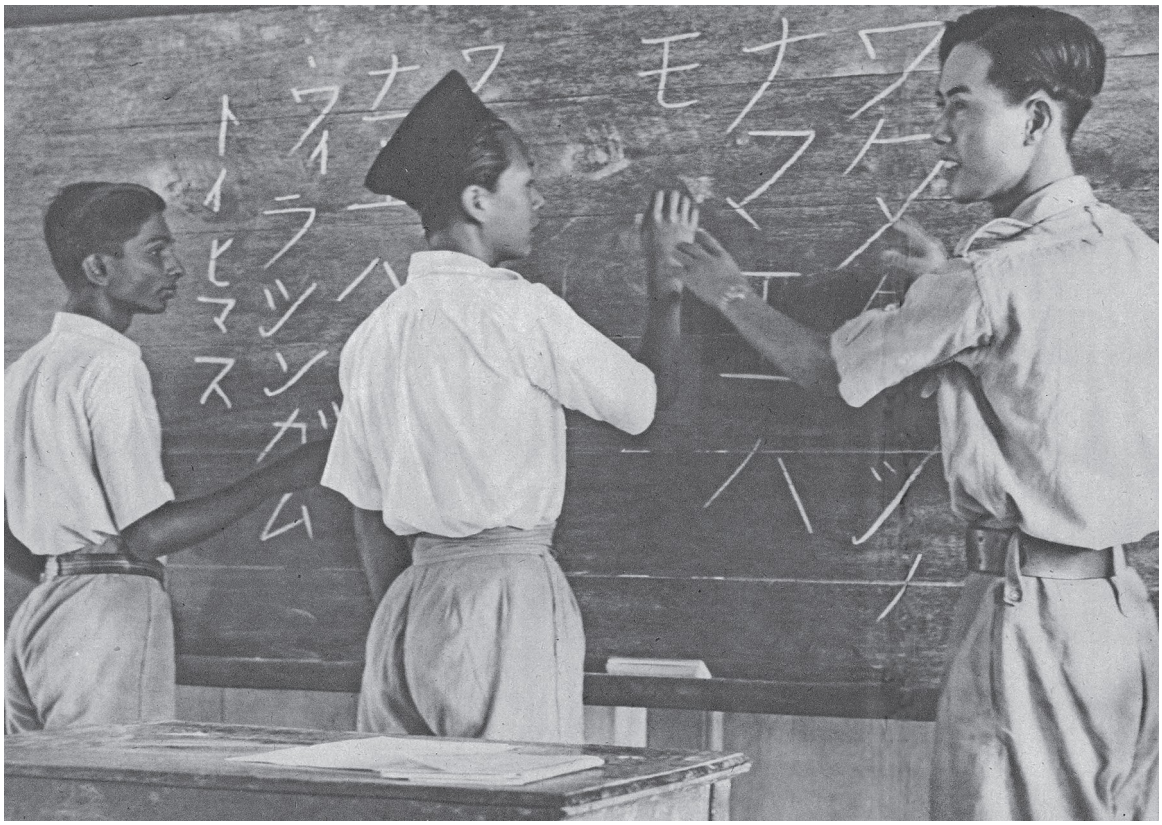
Document 7

Source: Japanese language class being taught by a Japanese instructor at a Singaporean school, circa 1943. Photograph published in *Asahi Shimbun*, one of Japan's major daily newspapers.



Asahi Shimbun / Getty Images

The British colony of Singapore fell to the Japanese armies in 1942.

END OF DOCUMENTS FOR QUESTION 1

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